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Nimmi

first met Nimmi in 1956 in Colombo.

I was in Ceylon (now Sri Lanka) to participate in another athletic competition, and she was there in her capacity as captain of the Indian women's volleyball team to play a friendly match against the Ceylonese. One day, while my friends and I were wandering around the bazaar, we came across a group of Indian girls and among them was Nimmi. As it always happens, when Indians, or for that matter any other nationalities, meet their fellow countrymen in an alien land, there is instant recognition and bonds of camaraderie are forged based on language, culture and traditions, even if they are total strangers. Inevitably, we struck up a conversation with them, and Nimmi insisted that I come to watch their match that evening. Naturally, I did not refuse, if for no other reason than to support her team.

I reached the venue two hours ahead of the scheduled time, full of anticipation. The Indian team was in full form, but Nimmi's performance was outstanding—her electric energy, superb high jumps and how she ran up to the net to hit the ball. It appeared as if she could beat the entire Ceylonese team singlehandedly on their home ground. Her skills were admirable.

I was eager to meet Nimmi again, but needed a valid excuse. I suggested to my friend, tea magnate Daljit Singh Sitara, that he host a reception at his residence in Ceylon for the victorious Indian volleyball team. His invitation was accepted and the dinner party was fixed for the next evening, after my race. The girls had demanded entry passes for my